(where he disembarked at Southampton on a grey September day in 1888, a naive and aspirant nineteen-year-old got up in what he believed were fashionable white flannels); South Africa, his home between 1893 and 1914, where he discovered his capacities to organize and protest, as well as an ability to invent for himself both a personality and a community; and, of course, India itself, where he returned in 1915 to become the moral dynamo and canny political brain of the vast Congress movement that took India to Independence and (to his despair) Partition, in 1947.

If *An Autobiography* exemplifies Gandhi's extraordinary talent for self-creation, it is also a testimony to the contradictions and insecurities, the isolation and inwardly-directed violence of this very public man. Gandhi achieved in it a language and expression of such directness and clarity that the reader who comes to it for the first time may find themselves gliding over it all too easily. Its simplicity can play tricks: it is a work of studied thought and artifice, and it is useful to recall something of the historical and cultural moment of its creation.

We know how to read political autobiographies – to check, suspiciously, self-projection against fact, subjective perception against objective structure – and we are perhaps familiar, too, with reading the testaments of religious leaders and saints. Gandhi's text, though, is different. It is the work of a man who saw himself neither as simply a political leader nor as uniquely a spiritual teacher, and it represents an effort to redefine each of these categories and ways of living. Both in the narrative voice it achieves, and in the distinctive interference it generates between